

SoftSpot

Product Requirements Document (PRD)

Author: Sumeda

Role: Product Manager & UX Designer

Project Type: Consumer Social Product • Design Sprint

Timeline: 2 Weeks

Background

Modern dating apps have made it easier than ever to meet new people, yet meaningful conversations remain difficult to start. Most platforms encourage users to make decisions based on a handful of photos and a short bio, leaving little room to understand personality, communication style, or long-term compatibility before matching.

SoftSpot reimagines the first interaction by placing meaningful conversation at the center of the experience. Inspired by We're Not Really Strangers, the product encourages users to answer thoughtful prompts that reveal personality, helping matches begin with curiosity rather than appearance. Through a gamified progression system, users deepen conversations together and eventually unlock personalized date suggestions based on shared interests.

This document outlines the product strategy, user research, MVP scope, success metrics, and roadmap required to bring SoftSpot from concept to launch.

User Problem

Users struggle to determine compatibility during the earliest stages of online dating. Existing dating platforms emphasize appearance first, making it difficult to understand whether two people share compatible values, communication styles, or relationship goals before investing time in a conversation. As a result, many conversations never begin or quickly lose momentum.

Business Problem

Dating platforms optimize for generating matches, but not necessarily for creating meaningful conversations after users match. This results in:

- Low first-message rates
- High conversation abandonment
- User frustration
- Reduced retention
- Lower long-term engagement

Opportunity

Help users build stronger first impressions by introducing compatibility before conversation, rather than after.

Product Vision

Help people build authentic relationships by making compatibility — not appearance — the starting point of every conversation.

Instead of encouraging users to “sell themselves” through carefully curated photos, SoftSpot creates opportunities for users to connect through thoughtful questions, shared values, and engaging conversations.

Product Goals

Primary Goal

- Increase meaningful conversations between matched users.

Secondary Goals

- Improve conversation quality
- Help users identify compatibility earlier
- Reduce ghosting after matching
- Increase user retention through engaging interactions
- Create a memorable dating experience focused on authenticity

Research Summary

Key Findings

44% joined dating apps to find long-term relationships	Emotional compatibility is important for many users.
40% joined for casual dating	Relationship intent should be communicated clearly.
38% would date someone outside their physical type	Attraction extends beyond first impressions.
64% value emotional maturity more than appearance	Personality is an underrepresented compatibility signal.

Competitive Analysis

Products analyzed:

- Tinder
- Bumble
- Hinge
- Coffee Meets Bagel

Observations

All four platforms primarily rely on photos and short biographies to drive matching decisions. While each app offers unique features, none place structured personality discovery at the center of the matching experience.

This creates an opportunity for a product focused on emotional compatibility rather than visual attraction.

User Personas

Persona 1 — Long-Term Relationship Seeker

Goals

- Find a meaningful relationship
- Connect through shared values
- Avoid superficial interactions

Frustrations

- Profiles all look similar
- Difficult to know someone's personality
- Conversations often feel repetitive

Persona 2 — Casual Explorer

Goals

- Meet interesting people
- Have enjoyable conversations
- Discover shared interests

Frustrations

- Awkward conversation starters
- Ghosting after matching
- Limited opportunities to express personality

Product Principles

Design for Authenticity

Encourage users to express who they are beyond carefully selected photos.

Reduce Conversation Friction

Provide meaningful prompts that naturally guide conversations.

Reward Emotional Connection

Progression should reflect genuine interaction instead of simple activity.

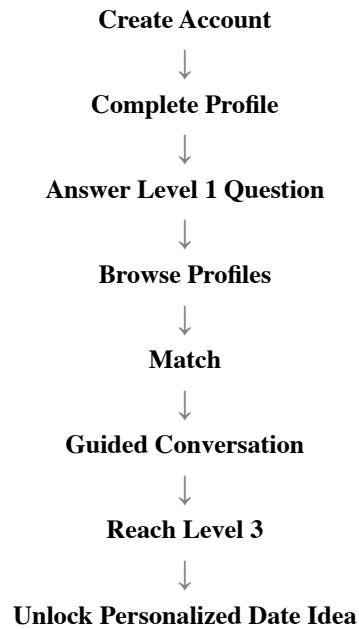
Proposed Solution

SoftSpot transforms compatibility into a collaborative experience.

Instead of swiping based solely on appearance, users answer thoughtful questions that become part of their profile. Matching considers both relationship intentions and question responses, allowing conversations to begin with shared interests instead of generic opening messages.

As users continue exchanging prompts, they unlock increasingly personal questions and eventually receive a personalized date suggestion tailored to their shared interests.

User Journey



MVP Scope

Must Have

User Profiles

- Name
- Age
- Photos
- Occupation
- School
- Relationship Intent

Deep Questions

- Level 1 profile question
- Question bank
- Personalized profile answers

Matching

- Browse profiles
- Accept / Reject
- Match confirmation

Guided Chat

- Conversation prompts
- Progress tracker

- Level progression

Date Suggestions

- Unlock personalized date recommendations after completing Level 3.

Future Features

- AI-generated conversation prompts
- Compatibility score
- Voice responses
- Shared photo prompts
- Personalized date recommendations
- Group dating experiences
- Video introductions

Success Metrics

North Star Metric

Meaningful Conversation Rate

Percentage of matched users exchanging at least five back-and-forth messages within 48 hours.

Supporting Metrics

Profile Completion Rate	Adoption of onboarding
Level 1 Question Completion	Usage of core feature
Match → First Reply Rate	Conversation initiation
Average Messages per Match	Conversation depth
Level 3 Completion	Engagement
Date Suggestion Acceptance	Offline conversion
7-Day Retention	Product stickiness
30-Day Retention	Long-term engagement

Success Definition

The MVP is considered successful if it demonstrates:

- Higher first-message rates than traditional dating apps
- Longer conversations between matched users
- Positive user feedback regarding conversation quality
- Strong onboarding completion
- Healthy weekly retention

Experimentation Plan

Experiment 1

Hypothesis

Displaying personality questions before matching increases first-message rates.

Measure

- Match → First Reply Rate

Experiment 2

Hypothesis

Gamified progression encourages longer conversations.

Measure

- Average Messages per Match
- Level Completion Rate

Experiment 3

Hypothesis

Displaying relationship intent improves match satisfaction.

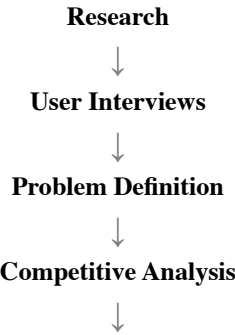
Measure

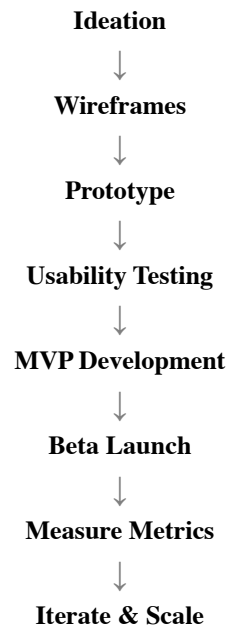
- User Satisfaction
- Conversation Completion

Risks

Users may feel uncomfortable answering personal questions too early.	Begin with lighter Level 1 prompts and gradually increase depth.
Too many onboarding questions may reduce profile completion.	Require only one prompt initially.
Gamification could feel forced.	Reward meaningful interaction rather than message quantity.

Product Roadmap





Future Opportunities

Following a successful MVP, future iterations could explore:

- AI-powered compatibility summaries
- Machine learning recommendations
- Personalized conversation coaching
- Calendar integration for planning dates
- Smart date recommendations based on interests
- Friend referrals
- Relationship milestone tracking

Reflection

SoftSpot began as a design sprint exploring how online dating could feel more authentic. Through research, competitive analysis, and rapid prototyping, the project evolved into a broader product strategy centered on reducing friction in the earliest stages of connection.

Reframing the concept as a product manager highlighted opportunities beyond interface design, including defining measurable success metrics, prioritizing MVP features, planning experiments, and thinking through long-term product growth. This project reinforced the importance of balancing user empathy with strategic decision-making to create experiences that are both meaningful and measurable.